

Beyond Clicks: From Gatekeeper to Interpreter in the Zero-Click Era

Abstract

AI-powered search tools like Google AI Overviews are reshaping how consumers discover brands. Instead of clicking through a list of ranked links, users now receive synthesized answers that collapse multiple touchpoints into a single AI-generated response. This “zero-click” environment is reducing direct traffic to brand websites and forcing marketers to rethink what visibility means in an era when influence happens upstream from the click. Our study sought to understand this transformation and identify how marketers can remain both visible and trusted. Through 21 interviews with senior marketing leaders across seven industries, we found that success now depends less on keyword optimization and more on semantic relevance and credibility. Structured, consistent online information distributed through owned and earned media is becoming increasingly important for marketers seeking to be discovered via search. Measurement practices must likewise evolve to capture influence and brand presence inside AI-generated results, not merely web traffic or click-through rates.

Keywords: AI search, generative AI, marketing, platform intermediation, search engine optimization, digital marketing

Introduction

Generative AI-powered search tools like Google AI Overviews continue to change the digital search ecosystem, comprising consumers, search engines, and marketers. For consumers, GenAI search reduces friction: instead of clicking through a list of ranked links, they receive a direct, AI-generated answer to their question. Research suggests that AI-powered search engines change information-seeking behavior by providing synthesized responses rather than requiring users to navigate multiple sources (Pham et al., 2024). In web search, this is called a "zero-click" result, when the answer appears directly on the results page, eliminating the need for users to visit the original content source (Bain & Company, 2025).

For marketers and the brands they work with, GenAI search presents a measurement challenge. Analysis of clickstream data from millions of devices reveals that approximately 60% of Google searches now end without any click to external websites, with only 360 clicks per 1,000 searches in the United States reaching non-Google properties (Fishkin, 2024). Search traffic has been central to how digital marketers track consumer awareness and interest, and visibility in search results has been a proxy for market attention. When consumers receive an answer directly from an AI rather than clicking through to a brand's website, marketers lose the ability to capture data about what consumers searched for and how they engaged with branded content. Traditional web analytics that track clicks, sessions, and conversions downstream from the search result page become less informative when the search itself becomes the endpoint of consumer attention.

This disruption extends beyond measurement. Industry observers note that publishers are beginning to take legal action against search platforms, alleging that AI-generated summaries reduce traffic to original content sources without proper attribution or compensation (Flynn, 2025). For marketers, the stakes are both informational and strategic: not only must they adapt to reduced visibility into consumer search behavior, but they must also determine how brands can remain discoverable when search engines mediate consumer attention through AI interpretation rather than link ranking.

As of early 2025, Google maintains a dominant market share in global search, with estimates placing its share at approximately 90% (Statcounter Global Stats, 2025). As Google expands its AI Overviews feature across categories and geographies, the implications for marketers intensify. This evolution in search behavior forces marketers to reconsider fundamental

assumptions about how consumers discover brands, what metrics indicate marketing effectiveness, and how organizations should structure their search strategies.

This study examines how marketing practitioners are navigating these changes. Through 21 in-depth interviews with senior marketing leaders across seven industries, we explore three emergent concerns: informational (what data marketers can access), organizational (how marketing work is restructured), and strategic (how brands achieve visibility). Our findings contribute to marketing communications scholarship by documenting an ongoing platform shift and identifying how search intermediaries are evolving from gatekeepers to interpreters of brand information.

Literature Review

The emergence of AI-powered search represents a convergence of three scholarly domains: search behavior, marketing measurement, and technology adoption by organizations. Understanding how these domains intersect clarifies both the disruption AI search creates and the strategic adaptations it demands. This exploratory study is grounded in literature on platform intermediation, technology acceptance, and marketing accountability challenges, positioning AI search as a phenomenon that reshapes how marketers access consumer information and how they collaborate to maintain brand visibility.

Consumer Search Behavior and Information-Seeking

Traditional search behavior has long been understood through different types of intent: informational, navigational, and transactional queries. Informational queries seek knowledge or answers; navigational queries aim to reach a specific destination; and transactional queries signal readiness to act. This typology has guided how search engines rank results and how marketers target consumers across the purchase funnel.

AI-powered search alters this landscape by synthesizing information from multiple sources into a single response. Rather than presenting ranked links that users must evaluate, AI search engines provide direct answers, effectively collapsing the search process. Evidence suggests that this shift changes information-seeking behavior: users rely on AI-generated summaries instead of navigating to multiple sources (Pham et al., 2024). When search engines provide synthesized answers, consumers no longer click through to brand websites at the same rate as they did in traditional search. This has significant implications for how marketers track consumer awareness

and measure engagement, as conventional web analytics depend on capturing user behavior downstream from the search result page.

Research on trust and reliance in AI-generated content provides further context. Users exhibit varying levels of trust in AI summaries depending on the perceived credibility of the underlying sources and the transparency of the generation process (Wang et al., 2025). This suggests that brand visibility in AI search may depend not only on semantic relevance but also on the credibility and authority that search algorithms attribute to a brand's online presence.

Platform Intermediation and Algorithmic Curation

Search engines have long functioned as intermediaries between consumers and content providers, shaping what information becomes visible through ranking algorithms. Traditional search intermediation operated through link-based curation: algorithms ranked websites, and users chose which results to click. The platform's role was primarily organizational, determining order and prominence within a list of options. Platform scholars have documented how digital intermediaries exercise power not merely through ranking but through the very architecture of information environments. Gillespie (2018) describes platforms as "custodians of the internet" (p. 23), responsible not just for organizing content but also for actively governing what users encounter. AI-generated search responses extend this custodial role from curation to synthesis: platforms now generate answers rather than simply pointing to sources, fundamentally shifting the locus of knowledge production.

This shift reflects broader patterns in platform evolution. Van Dijck et al. (2018) argue that platforms increasingly penetrate societal structures, transforming from neutral channels into active shapers of social, economic, and informational relationships. When search engines generate direct answers, they move from connecting users to information sources toward replacing those sources in users' information-seeking process. The platform becomes the destination rather than the pathway.

The transition carries implications for what Plantin et al. (2018) term "infrastructuralization"—the process by which platforms become so embedded in everyday practice that their mediation becomes invisible. Google's evolution from organizing the web's information to generating its own answers represents this infrastructural shift. For content providers, exclusion from AI-generated responses may represent not just reduced visibility but functional invisibility within an increasingly answer-based search paradigm.

These dynamics create what Van Dijck (2021) identifies as fundamental information asymmetries. Platforms possess comprehensive data about how their algorithms select, synthesize, and present information, while both users and content providers operate with limited visibility into these processes. For marketers, this opacity extends to uncertainty about what signals or content characteristics influence inclusion in AI responses, complicating efforts to maintain brand visibility in search.

Recent scholarship on platform intermediation (Kuai et al., 2025) examines how algorithmic curation shapes information environments. When AI search synthesizes information from multiple sources into a single response, the platform's interpretive role intensifies. Rather than presenting ranked options for user evaluation, the platform itself becomes the interpreter, making judgments about which sources to privilege, how to weigh conflicting information, and what constitutes an adequate answer. This transformation from gatekeeper to interpreter fundamentally alters the relationship between platforms, content creators, and information seekers (Kuai et al., 2025).

Marketing Accountability and Measurement Challenges

The marketing measurement literature has long grappled with challenges of attribution, accountability, and proving return on investment. Morgan and colleagues (2019) note that marketing's influence is often diffuse and difficult to isolate, making it challenging for marketers to demonstrate value to organizational stakeholders. Recent work further documents how marketing teams struggle to measure the effectiveness of digital campaigns when consumer touchpoints multiply, and attribution becomes more complex (Morgan et al., 2022).

AI search compounds these measurement challenges. When consumers receive answers directly from search results without clicking through to brand websites, marketers lose access to behavioral data that has traditionally informed strategy. Web analytics platforms that track page views, sessions, bounce rates, and conversion funnels become less informative when the search itself becomes the endpoint of consumer attention. This loss of visibility raises fundamental questions about how marketers can track awareness, gauge interest, and measure the effectiveness of search-related marketing investments.

Technology Adoption in Marketing Organizations

Research on marketing automation adoption highlights that successful implementation depends not only on technical capabilities but also on organizational readiness, collaborative

practices, and alignment across functional teams (Silva et al., 2023). Recent research examining advertising professionals' responses to generative AI reveals that adoption is shaped by both excitement about productivity gains and anxiety about workflow disruption (Lim et al., 2024). This means that integrating AI tools into marketing workflows requires marketers to develop new skills, adjust existing processes, and rethink how work is coordinated across teams.

Broader research on technology acceptance suggests that user perceptions of ease of use, usefulness, and trust influence adoption patterns (Marikyan et al., 2023). For marketing practitioners navigating AI search, these factors shape how teams experiment with new tools, allocate resources, and decide when to adopt AI-driven strategies. Understanding how marketers are currently using AI, and where they see barriers, provides insight into the organizational dynamics that will shape the evolution of search marketing over time.

Recent research on AI adoption in marketing organizations extends these technology acceptance frameworks to the specific challenges of interactive marketing contexts. Gastmann and Bastos (2024) documented productivity gains from generative AI in social media marketing, highlighting how AI tools reshape marketing workflows and strategic decision-making. Peltier et al. (2024) synthesized findings from over 300 studies to develop a value co-creation framework for AI in buyer-seller relationships, identifying key gaps in how marketers understand and implement AI tools for customer engagement. Their extensive review reveals that successful AI adoption requires not only technical infrastructure but also organizational clarity about how AI transforms the mechanisms through which marketing creates value. AI search represents one manifestation of this broader transformation, in which the technology changes both the information available to marketers and the ways brands can participate in customers' information-seeking processes.

Theoretical Framework: From Gatekeeper to Interpreter

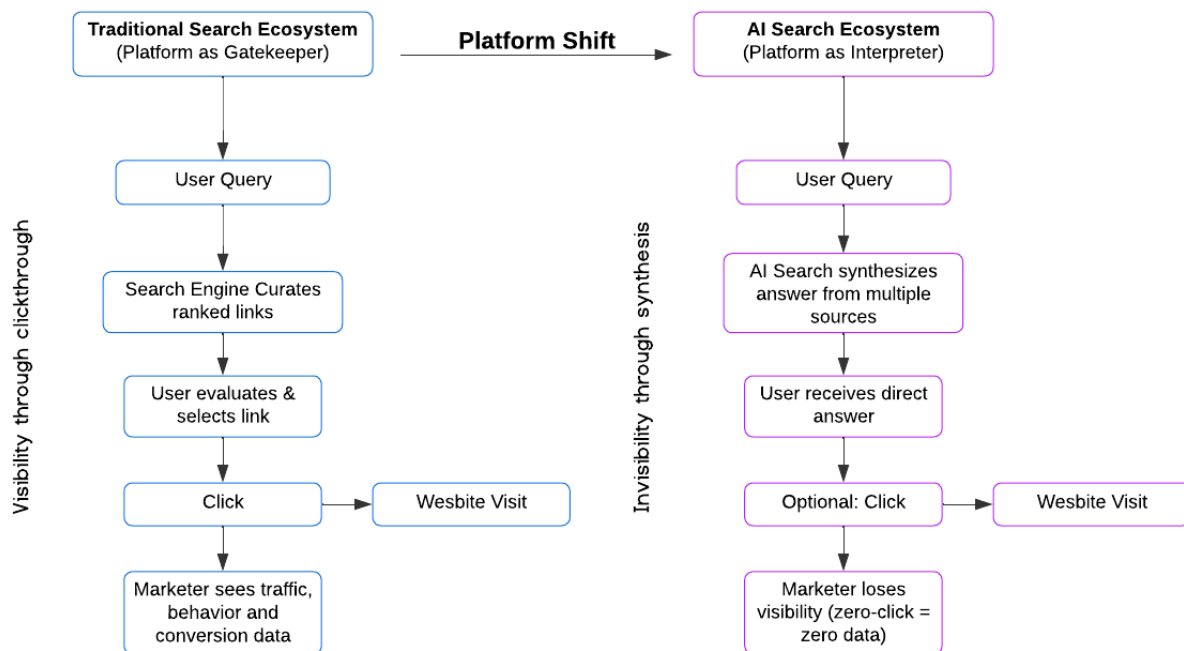
Building on this literature, this study positions AI search as a platform shift, transforming search engines from gatekeepers to interpreters (see Figure 1). In traditional search, platforms gatekeep by ranking content and determining which links appear prominently. Users then navigate to those links and interpret the content themselves. In AI search, platforms interpret content directly, synthesizing information across sources and presenting a generated response. This interpretive role concentrates both informational power and strategic influence within the algorithm, reshaping what marketers must do to remain visible and trusted.

This study contributes to marketing communications theory by reconceptualizing digital platforms not merely as gatekeepers of information but as interpretive intermediaries that actively construct brand meaning. While prior research has examined platforms as curators of visibility, our findings show that AI-powered search systems synthesize, prioritize, and recombine brand messages across sources, thereby reshaping how meaning is produced and received in marketing communication. In this context, interpretive intermediation refers to the process by which platforms actively construct brand meaning by synthesizing, prioritizing, and presenting information from multiple sources into a unified response.

We adopt an exploratory approach to examine how practitioners are navigating this shift. Rather than testing a priori hypotheses, this study aims to surface emergent concerns, document adaptive strategies, and identify areas where existing theory may require extension. Our analysis reveals three overlapping domains of practitioner concern, namely informational, organizational, and strategic, each reflecting different facets of the disruption AI search creates for marketing communications.

Figure 1

From Gatekeeper to Interpreter: The Shift in Platform Intermediation



Methodology

To understand how marketers are responding to GenAI search, we conducted 21 in-depth, semi-structured interviews with vice presidents, marketing directors, and digital strategy leads from organizations across healthcare, finance, consumer packaged goods (CPG), retail, nonprofit, technology, and education, all based in the United States. Participants were selected through purposive sampling to capture perspectives across industries experiencing different degrees of AI search disruption. All participants held senior marketing roles with direct responsibility for search strategy, digital marketing measurement, or cross-channel campaign management.

Research Design and Data Collection

Interviews were conducted over three months in the summer of 2025 via video conferencing platforms. Each interview lasted 45-75 minutes and followed a semi-structured protocol designed to elicit practitioner perspectives on three core topics: (1) observed changes in search behavior and traffic patterns, (2) organizational responses to AI search tools, and (3) strategic adaptations in measurement and content strategy.

Interview questions were organized around four research questions:

- RQ1: How has GenAI affected the search market in 2025?
- RQ2: How are digital marketing teams using GenAI?
- RQ3: What outlook do digital marketing experts have on GenAI search?
- RQ4: What types of barriers do digital marketers face when leveraging GenAI?

Probes were used to encourage participants to provide concrete examples, describe specific challenges, and reflect on organizational dynamics. All interviews were audio-recorded with participant consent and transcribed verbatim for analysis. All participants were informed about the research purpose and provided verbal consent before interviews. Participation was voluntary, and participants could withdraw at any time without penalty.

Data Analysis

Interview transcripts were analyzed using an inductive thematic analysis approach (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Two researchers independently read all transcripts multiple times to identify recurring patterns across participant responses. Emergent themes were identified through iterative engagement with the data, grouping related concepts, and refining the thematic structure through successive readings. The researchers met regularly to discuss emerging patterns and reach consensus on the final thematic framework. The final themes were developed to capture the primary concerns and perspectives expressed by participants regarding AI search.

Results

Analysis of the in-depth interviews revealed three domains of practitioner concern as marketers navigate AI search: informational concerns (what data is available), organizational concerns (how work is restructured), and strategic concerns (how visibility is achieved) (see Table 1). These domains are interconnected, reflecting how changes in available data reshape both organizational practices and strategic priorities.

Informational Concerns: What Data Is Available

The shift to AI-generated search results fundamentally disrupts the information marketers can access about consumer search behavior. Participants described three specific informational challenges: understanding variation in consumer intent, measuring visibility in a zero-click environment, and navigating algorithmic opacity.

Consumer Intent Variation

Participants noted that AI overviews affect different types of search queries unevenly. Informational queries, where users seek knowledge or answers, convert to zero-click results at high rates. As one healthcare marketing director explained:

"If someone searches 'what are symptoms of diabetes,' Google AI Overviews gives them the answer right there. They don't need to click through to our website anymore."

In contrast, commercial and navigational queries still generate website traffic, as users conducting transactional searches (e.g., "buy running shoes online") or seeking specific destinations (e.g., brand names) are more likely to click through. However, the boundaries between query types are fluid. Several participants observed that searches that previously drove traffic to their websites now end with an AI-generated response. A retail marketing leader noted:

"We used to get a lot of traffic from 'how to' searches—how to style a dress, how to clean leather boots. Now Google answers those questions directly, and we lose that top-of-funnel visibility."

This variation in how AI search handles different intent types complicates measurement. Marketers can no longer rely on aggregate search traffic metrics, as those metrics conflate queries with fundamentally different conversion patterns. Understanding which specific searches now terminate at AI overviews, and which still drive clicks, requires granular analysis that many teams lack the tools or time to conduct.

Measurement Visibility Paradox

The second informational concern centers on measurement. Traditional web analytics depend on capturing user behavior downstream from the search result page: page views, sessions, bounce rates, and conversion funnels. When consumers receive answers directly from AI search results without clicking through to brand websites, marketers lose access to these behavioral signals.

A technology marketing vice president described the challenge:

"We used to track exactly what people searched for before landing on our site. That gave us insight into what they cared about, what language they used, and what problems they were trying to solve. With AI Overviews, we don't get that anymore. We're flying blind on a lot of top-of-funnel activity."

Paradoxically, this loss of visibility occurs even as the total volume of brand mentions in AI-generated responses may increase. Multiple participants reported that their brands appear in Google AI Overviews more frequently than in traditional organic search results, yet they have no systematic way to track when, where, or how often this occurs. As a CPG marketing director put it:

"We know our brand is showing up in these AI summaries because we see it anecdotally. But we can't measure it the way we measure everything else. There's no dashboard, no API, no reporting."

Several participants expressed frustration that Google provides limited transparency into how AI Overviews select and synthesize content. Without knowing which signals the algorithm prioritizes, marketers struggle to optimize their online presence for AI discovery. This informational asymmetry, in which platforms possess rich data on brand visibility in AI search but do not share it with marketers, creates strategic uncertainty, reflecting a breakdown in traditional communication feedback loops between brands and audiences.

Algorithmic Opacity

The third informational concern relates to algorithmic opacity. Participants described AI search as a "black box" where the rules governing brand visibility remain unclear. Unlike traditional search engine optimization (SEO), where marketers developed heuristics about ranking factors (keywords, backlinks, page authority), GenAI Optimization (GEO) lacks established best practices.

A nonprofit marketing lead explained:

"With SEO, we had years of trial and error. We knew what worked: good content, relevant keywords, authoritative links. With GEO, we're starting from scratch. No one really knows what makes AI pick your brand over someone else's."

This opacity extends to attribution. When an AI-generated answer cites multiple sources, marketers cannot determine which specific content the algorithm drew upon or why. A finance industry marketer noted:

"Sometimes our content gets cited; sometimes it doesn't. We can't figure out the pattern. Is it because our content is more authoritative? More recent? Better structured? We're guessing."

The lack of feedback loops worsens this challenge. In traditional search, marketers could test changes such as adjusting keywords, updating meta descriptions, building backlinks, and observing how rankings shifted (Cutler, 2023). In AI search, the absence of measurable signals makes experimentation difficult. Without knowing what works, marketers struggle to allocate resources effectively or justify search-related investments to organizational stakeholders. This limits transparency in how marketing messages are selected and reconstructed.

Organizational Concerns: How Work Is Restructured

Beyond informational challenges, AI search reshapes how marketing teams collaborate internally and partner externally. Participants described two organizational concerns: fragmentation of internal collaboration and tensions in external partnerships. This represents a shift from optimizing message delivery to influencing how platforms construct meaning.

Internal Collaboration Fragmentation

Several participants noted that AI search blurs the boundaries between functional roles within marketing organizations. Traditionally, SEO specialists, content strategists, PR teams, and paid search managers operated with relatively distinct responsibilities. AI search disrupts these divisions, as brand visibility now depends on coordinated efforts across owned, earned, and paid media.

A technology company marketing director explained:

"AI pulls information from everywhere—our website, third-party reviews, news articles, social media. That means SEO can't work in isolation anymore. They need to coordinate with PR to make sure press coverage is accurate, with content to make sure our messaging is consistent, with product marketing to make sure technical specs are up to date."

This coordination requires new workflows and communication practices. However, several participants reported that their organizations had not yet adapted structures to support this cross-functional collaboration. As one retail marketer put it:

"We're still organized in silos. SEO reports to one person, PR to another, and content to a third. Getting them to work together on an AI search strategy is like herding cats."

The challenge extends to resource allocation. When brand visibility depends on information distributed across multiple channels, it becomes difficult to determine where to invest. Should budgets prioritize website content optimization, third-party review management, media relations, or social media presence? Several participants described internal debates over which team should "own" the AI search strategy and how to measure the contribution of different channels.

External Partnership Tensions

The second organizational concern involves tensions with external partners, particularly agencies and technology vendors. Multiple participants described AI search as creating misalignment between their strategic priorities and their partners' or colleagues' incentives.

A healthcare marketer explained:

"Our agency gets paid based on clicks and conversions. But with AI Overviews, we're seeing fewer clicks even though brand awareness might be going up. The agency's incentive is still to drive traffic, but that's not always what we need anymore."

Similar tensions emerged with technology vendors. SEO software providers have historically focused on tracking keyword rankings and backlinks, enabling marketers to monitor search performance and identify optimization opportunities (Cutler, 2023). As AI search becomes more prominent, these tools provide less actionable insight. Several participants expressed frustration that vendor roadmaps had not kept pace with the shift to AI-generated results.

Additionally, participants noted concerns about intellectual property and attribution when working with agencies. If an agency creates content that gets synthesized into an AI-generated answer, questions arise about who gets credit and how value is measured.

A finance industry marketer noted:

"If our agency writes a great blog post that gets pulled into an AI Overview, does that count as success? Do we pay them for the content or for the traffic? It's unclear."

These partnership tensions reflect deeper questions about how marketing work is valued and measured in an AI search environment. When traditional performance metrics (clicks, sessions, conversions) become less informative, marketers and their partners must renegotiate expectations and redefine success.

Strategic Concerns: How Visibility Is Achieved

The final domain of practitioner concern centers on strategy: how brands can remain visible and trusted when search engines mediate attention through AI interpretation rather than link ranking. Participants identified two strategic shifts: from SEO to GEO, and from keyword ranking to semantic authority.

From SEO to GEO

Multiple participants described a strategic pivot from Search Engine Optimization (SEO) to what they termed Generative Engine Optimization (GEO). Whereas SEO focuses on ranking highly for specific keywords, GEO emphasizes ensuring that a brand's information, across all online sources, is structured, consistent, and authoritative enough to be selected for AI-generated responses.

A CPG marketing vice president explained:

"SEO was about being number one for our target keywords. GEO is about making sure the information about our brand, wherever it lives online, is accurate and comprehensive. It's less about ranking and more about being the source the AI trusts."

This shift requires new tactics. Several participants emphasized the importance of structured data (schema markup, knowledge graphs) to help AI systems parse and understand brand information. Others highlighted the need for consistency across channels: ensuring that product descriptions, company overviews, and brand messaging are aligned across owned websites, third-party platforms, review sites, and news articles.

A retail marketing director noted:

"We realized we were putting different product descriptions on our website, on Amazon, on retailer sites. When AI pulled information from multiple sources, it created conflicting answers. Now we have a single source of truth and push that content everywhere."

GEO also involves proactive engagement with platforms where brand information is published. Several participants described efforts to update company profiles on review sites, business directories, and knowledge bases to ensure accuracy.

As one technology marketer put it:

"You can't just optimize your own website anymore. You have to think about the entire ecosystem where information about your brand exists."

Semantic Authority Over Keyword Ranking

The second strategic shift involves moving from keyword optimization to semantic authority. In traditional SEO, marketers targeted specific search terms and optimized content to rank for those keywords. In AI search, algorithms prioritize content that demonstrates broader topical authority and credibility rather than exact keyword matches.

A finance industry marketing lead explained:

"AI doesn't just match keywords. It interprets meaning. So instead of optimizing for 'best savings account,' we focus on being recognized as an authoritative source on personal finance topics broadly. That means publishing comprehensive content, getting cited by reputable sources, and building subject matter expertise."

Several participants noted that earned media and third-party validation have become more important. Press coverage, academic citations, expert endorsements, and high-quality backlinks signal credibility to AI systems. A healthcare marketer observed:

"When AI generates an answer, it cites sources it considers authoritative. Getting our content cited means we need to be seen as a trusted source, not just rank well for keywords."

This emphasis on authority over ranking has implications for content strategy. Rather than creating numerous short, keyword-focused pages, several participants described shifting toward fewer, more comprehensive resources that establish thought leadership.

A nonprofit marketing director explained:

"We used to create a lot of blog posts targeting long-tail keywords. Now we're focusing on pillar content—in-depth guides, research reports, expert interviews—that position us as the go-to source on our issues."

The shift also affects measurement. Participants acknowledged that traditional metrics such as keyword rankings and search positions are less meaningful when AI synthesizes information from multiple sources. Instead, they are exploring alternative indicators: brand mentions in AI-generated responses, citation frequency, and share of voice in topical conversations. However, many noted that these metrics remain difficult to track systematically.

Table 1.

Overview of Emergent Themes

Theme	Central Challenge	Key Concerns
Informational	What marketers can access about consumer search behavior	• Loss of clickstream data and behavioral signals • Inability to measure brand presence in AI responses • Opacity in algorithmic content selection
Organizational	How marketing work is restructured	• Fragmented internal collaboration across SEO, PR, and content teams • Misaligned agency partnerships and compensation models • Unclear resource allocation priorities
Strategic	How brands achieve visibility in AI search	• Shift from keyword ranking (SEO) to semantic authority (GEO) • Importance of structured data and information consistency • Growing role of earned media and third-party validation

Discussion

This study reveals how AI search disrupts both the information marketers can access about consumers and the collaborative practices through which marketing teams respond. Our findings contribute to marketing communications scholarship in three ways: advancing understanding of platform intermediation, documenting measurement challenges in an evolving digital ecosystem, and identifying how organizational structures adapt to technological change.

Theoretical Contributions

First, our findings extend research on platform intermediation (Kuai et al., 2025) by documenting a shift from gatekeeping to interpretation. In traditional search, platforms gatekeep

by ranking content and determining which links appear prominently. Users then navigate to those links and interpret content themselves. In AI search, platforms interpret content directly, synthesizing information across sources and presenting a generated response. This interpretive role concentrates both informational power and strategic influence within the algorithm, fundamentally reshaping what marketers must do to remain visible and trusted.

The "gatekeeper to interpreter" framework developed in this study highlights how AI search changes the locus of control in brand discovery. Whereas SEO strategies focused on achieving high rankings within a gatekeeper's list, GEO strategies must ensure that a brand's information, distributed across owned, earned, and third-party sources, is structured, consistent, and authoritative enough to be selected by an interpreting algorithm. This shift has implications beyond search marketing, as other platforms (social media, e-commerce sites, streaming services) increasingly deploy AI to mediate user attention.

Second, our findings contribute to scholarship on marketing accountability and measurement (Morgan et al., 2019; Morgan et al., 2022). The informational challenges practitioners described, such as loss of behavioral signals, inability to track brand presence in AI-generated responses, and opacity in algorithmic selection, compound existing difficulties in demonstrating marketing value. When traditional metrics like traffic, clicks, and conversions become less informative, marketers face renewed pressure to justify investments and prove impact. Future research should explore alternative measurement frameworks that capture brand influence within AI-mediated environments, such as citation frequency, share of voice in topical conversations, or semantic authority within knowledge graphs.

Third, this study documents organizational dynamics that emerge as marketing teams navigate technological disruption. As Lim et al. (2024) demonstrate, marketing professionals' responses to AI adoption are characterized by both opportunity and apprehension. Successful adaptation requires marketers to develop new competencies for working alongside AI systems (McAlister et al., 2024). The fragmentation of internal collaboration and tensions in external partnerships reflect deeper challenges in coordinating work when traditional role boundaries blur. Our findings suggest that successful adaptation may require not only new tools and tactics but also structural changes in how marketing organizations allocate resources, define responsibilities, and measure performance. This aligns with prior research on marketing automation adoption (Silva et

al., 2023), which emphasizes that technological integration depends on organizational readiness and collaborative capacity.

Practical Implications

For marketing practitioners, this study offers several actionable insights. First, the shift from SEO to GEO requires a strategic reorientation toward consistency and authority across all online sources. Marketers should audit their brand's information footprint, such as owned websites, third-party platforms, review sites, news articles, and social media, and ensure that content is accurate, comprehensive, and structured in ways that AI systems can parse. Implementing schema markup, maintaining knowledge graph profiles, and actively managing third-party listings become essential tasks.

Second, the measurement visibility paradox suggests that marketers should develop proxy indicators for brand presence in AI search. While direct metrics remain elusive, practitioners can track anecdotal observations (screenshots of AI-generated responses featuring their brand), monitor changes in branded search volume, and assess shifts in downstream conversion patterns. Investing in qualitative research, such as user testing, to understand how consumers perceive and interact with AI search results, may provide valuable context that quantitative analytics cannot capture.

Third, organizational adaptation requires cross-functional collaboration. Marketing leaders should break down silos between SEO, content, PR, and paid search teams, creating integrated workflows that coordinate efforts across channels now more than ever. Establishing clear ownership of the AI search strategy and aligning incentives across internal teams and external partners will be critical for executing coordinated GEO initiatives.

Fourth, the emphasis on semantic authority over keyword ranking suggests that content strategy should prioritize depth over breadth. Rather than creating numerous keyword-focused pages, marketers should invest in comprehensive, authoritative resources that establish thought leadership. Earned media, third-party validation, and expert endorsements signal credibility to AI systems and should be integrated into content and PR strategies.

Our findings illuminate how the gatekeeper-to-interpreter shift manifests in practitioner experience. The informational concerns, particularly reduced transparency and algorithmic opacity, directly reflect how interpretation-based search obscures the curation logic that was

visible when platforms simply ranked results. Practitioners could previously reverse-engineer ranking algorithms through testing; now, the synthesis process is opaque.

Future Research Directions

Several avenues for future research emerge from this study. First, consumer search intent warrants deeper examination. Our findings indicate that AI overviews affect different intent types unevenly. Informational queries convert to zero-click at high rates, while commercial and navigational searches still drive website traffic. Yet the boundaries remain fluid. Longitudinal studies tracking how different query categories evolve over time, combined with experimental research testing how consumers respond to AI-generated answers versus traditional search results, would provide valuable insight.

Second, measurement frameworks require development and validation. This study documented practitioners' frustration with the lack of tools to track brand presence in AI search. Researchers could collaborate with platform providers to develop transparent metrics for AI-generated response attribution or design alternative measurement systems that capture brand influence in zero-click environments. Quantitative validation of practitioner-identified indicators (e.g., citation frequency) would strengthen the empirical foundation for measuring AI search.

Third, organizational adaptation requires continued attention. How do marketing organizations restructure roles, workflows, and incentives to support integrated GEO strategies? What leadership practices facilitate successful cross-functional collaboration? Comparative case studies examining organizations at different stages of AI search adaptation would illuminate effective organizational responses.

Fourth, cross-cultural and international perspectives are needed. This study focused primarily on US-based marketers navigating Google's AI Overviews. Different search ecosystems (e.g., Baidu in China, Yandex in Russia, Naver in South Korea) and varying regulatory environments may shape how AI search evolves globally. International comparative research would reveal whether the concerns and adaptations documented here generalize across contexts or reflect region-specific dynamics.

Finally, consumer-side research is essential. This study examined practitioner perspectives on AI search disruption. Understanding how consumers perceive, trust, and rely on AI-generated search results, and how these perceptions vary across demographics, literacy levels, and use

contexts, would complement this study's organizational focus and provide a more complete picture of the evolving search ecosystem.

Limitations

This study has several limitations that warrant caution when generalizing its findings. First, our sample of 21 senior marketing professionals, while providing rich insights, represents a specific segment of the practitioner community. Perspectives from mid-level marketers, agency professionals, or international contexts may differ. The purposive sampling approach prioritized industry diversity but may not capture the full range of organizational responses to AI search disruption.

Second, our cross-sectional design captures practitioner perspectives at a single point in time during a period of rapid technological change. AI search tools continue to evolve, and the concerns practitioners expressed in 2025 may shift as platforms refine their algorithms, introduce new features, or face regulatory pressure. Longitudinal research tracking how practitioner perceptions and strategies adapt over time would provide valuable temporal context.

Third, this study relies on self-reported perceptions rather than behavioral or performance data. Participants described their experiences navigating AI search, but we did not independently verify traffic patterns, measure actual brand presence in AI-generated responses, or assess the effectiveness of specific GEO tactics. Future research combining interview data with quantitative metrics (e.g., web analytics, AI response tracking, conversion data) would strengthen empirical claims about the impact of AI search on marketing outcomes.

Fourth, the study's focus on practitioner perspectives means that consumer experiences remain underexplored. Understanding how users perceive and interact with AI-generated search results, how they assess the credibility of synthesized information, and how their search behaviors are changing would complement the organizational focus of this research.

Finally, our findings reflect experiences primarily with Google AI Overviews in the US market. Different search platforms, international contexts, and varying regulatory environments may produce different dynamics. The extent to which our findings generalize beyond this specific platform and geography remains an empirical question.

Conclusion

AI-powered search represents a fundamental shift in how consumers discover brands and how marketers measure visibility. This exploratory study documented how senior marketing

practitioners are navigating informational, organizational, and strategic challenges as search engines evolve from gatekeepers to interpreters. Our findings reveal that success in this new environment depends less on keyword optimization and more on semantic relevance, credibility, and authority distributed across a brand's entire online ecosystem. As AI search continues to evolve, marketers must adapt measurement frameworks, restructure collaborative practices, and develop new strategies for maintaining brand visibility in an environment where the algorithm mediates attention through synthesis rather than ranking. The shift from SEO to GEO marks not merely a tactical adjustment but a fundamental reorientation in how marketing communications functions within platform-mediated digital ecosystems.

References

- Bain & Company. (2025). Goodbye clicks, hello AI: Zero-click search redefines marketing. <https://www.bain.com/insights/goodbye-clicks-hello-ai-zero-click-search-redefines-marketing/>
- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3(2), 77-101.
- Cutler, K. (2023). Search marketing: A strategic approach to SEO and SEM. Kogan Page Publishers.
- Fishkin, R. (2024, July 1). Zero-click searches: 2024 study of millions of searches on mobile and desktop. SparkToro. <https://sparktoro.com/blog/zero-click-searches-2024-study/>
- Flynn, K. (2025). Penske Media sues Google over AI summaries taking traffic. Axios. <https://www.axios.com/2025/01/08/penske-media-google-lawsuit-ai-summaries>
- Gastmann, J., & Bastos, M. (2025). Strategising with generative AI: Productivity gains in social media marketing. *Journal of Marketing Communications*, 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13527266.2025.2525913>
- Gillespie, T. (2018). *Custodians of the internet: Platforms, content moderation, and the hidden decisions that shape social media*. Yale University Press.
- Kuai, J., Brantner, C., Karlsson, M., Van Couvering, E., & Romano, S. (2025). AI chatbot accountability in the age of algorithmic gatekeeping: Comparing generative search engine political information retrieval across five languages. *New Media & Society*, 0(0).
- Lim, R. E., Kim, S., Abernathy, A., Shin, S., & Avance, R. (2025). Excited or anxious about adopting generative AI? Investigating the drivers of generative AI adoption among advertising creatives. *Journal of Marketing Communications*, 1–24. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13527266.2025.2497259>

- Marikyan, D., Papagiannidis, S., & Alamanos, E. (2023). A systematic review of the smart home literature: A user perspective. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 138, 139-154.
- McAlister, A. R., Alhabash, S., & Yang, J. (2024). Artificial intelligence and ChatGPT: Exploring Current and potential future roles in marketing education. *Journal of Marketing Communications*, 30(2), 166–187. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13527266.2023.2289034>
- Morgan, N. A., Whitler, K. A., Feng, H., & Chari, S. (2019). Research in marketing strategy. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 47, 4-29.
- Morgan, N. A., Jayachandran, S., Hulland, J., Kumar, B., Katsikeas, C., & Somosi, A. (2022). Marketing performance assessment and accountability: Process and outcomes. *International Journal of Research in Marketing*, 39(2), 462-481.
- Peltier, J. W., Dahl, A. J., & Schibrowsky, J. A. (2024). Artificial intelligence in interactive marketing: A conceptual framework and research agenda. *Journal of Research in Interactive Marketing*, 18(1), 54-90. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JRIM-01-2023-0030>
- Pham, V. K., Pham Thi, T. D., & Duong, N. T. (2024). A study on information search behavior using AI-powered engines: Evidence from chatbots on online shopping platforms. *Sage Open*, 14(4). <https://doi.org/10.1177/21582440241300007>
- Plantin, J.-C., Lagoze, C., Edwards, P. N., & Sandvig, C. (2018). Infrastructure studies meet platform studies in the age of Google and Facebook. *New Media & Society*, 20(1), 293-310. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444816661553>
- Silva, S. C., Corbo, L., Vlačić, B., & Fernandes, M. (2023). Marketing accountability and marketing automation: evidence from Portugal. *EuroMed Journal of Business*, 18(1), 145-164

Statcounter Global Stats. (2025). Search engine market share worldwide.

<https://gs.statcounter.com>

Van Dijck, J. (2021). Governing digital societies: Private platforms, public values. *Computer Law & Security Review*, 41, 105577. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clsr.2021.105577>

Van Dijck, J., Poell, T., & de Waal, M. (2018). *The platform society: Public values in a connective world*. Oxford University Press.

Wang, Y., Chen, H., Wei, X., & Chang, C. (2025). Trusting the machine: Exploring participant perceptions of AI-driven summaries in virtual focus groups with and without human oversight. *Computers in Human Behavior Artificial Humans*, 6, 100198. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chbah.2025.100198>